Semester-long interview prep syllabus: a 16-week student roadmap covering STAR behavioral practice, mock interviews, and career center tools

Computer
Turn career center interview tools into a 16-week student curriculum — modules, STAR rubrics, and automated grading rubrics
Computer
Show me the interactive interview practice workflow
How should the AI feedback system evaluate STAR responses
Detail the resume and evidence portfolio integration

Semester should offer a **16-week** interview-preparation curriculum that connects career exploration, résumé development, evidence portfolios, STAR practice, AI-guided improvement, and human mock interviews in one student-controlled workflow.

Below is a proposed syllabus, interactive practice flow, STAR assessment system, and résumé–portfolio integration specification. It is a design and implementation artifact—not a claim that these workflows are already deployed. Your existing career design provides the foundation: applications, preparation prompts, evidence artifacts, skills, portfolio export, alumni connections, and Career Center support.[1]

1. Curriculum structure and learning outcomes

Course model

Proposed title: Career Evidence and Interview Practice Studio.

- Duration: 16 weeks.
- Suggested workload: approximately two hours per week, adjustable around student commitments.
- Format: short learning modules, individual practice, peer or coach feedback, and portfolio development.
- Entry requirement: no prior internship or professional interview experience.
- Practice options: text, voice, and optional recording, with accessible alternatives.
- Assessment purpose: develop interview skills and credible evidence—not predict employability.
- Human support: career staff review at key milestones.

The curriculum follows the sequence recommended in MIT's interview toolkit: examine the job posting, cross-reference the résumé, identify relevant experiences, outline STAR responses, research the employer, and practice with different people.[2]

End-of-semester outcomes

Students should be able to:

1. Interpret an opportunity's stated requirements.
2. Select real experiences that demonstrate relevant capabilities.
3. Explain their individual contributions without overstating team achievements.
4. Construct clear STAR responses.
5. Respond to follow-up questions without relying on a memorized script.
6. Present a résumé and evidence portfolio consistently.
7. Research an employer and prepare meaningful questions.
8. Complete a mock interview and use feedback to improve.
9. Manage interview logistics and appropriate follow-up.
10. Identify when human coaching or specialist guidance is needed.

Semester deliverables

Proposed completion targets:

- One baseline interview and reflection.
- One targeted résumé with version history.
- An evidence portfolio containing four to six student-selected artifacts.
- A story bank containing eight to twelve genuine experiences.
- Several short practice-and-retry cycles.
- Three full mock interviews, including at least one human-reviewed session.
- One employer and role briefing.
- One final interview-preparation packet.
- One reflection describing changes, remaining gaps, and next actions.

These are curriculum targets, not validated thresholds for career readiness. Institutions should adapt them to course credit, staffing, accessibility, and student needs.

2. The 16-week student roadmap

Week	Module and learning objective	Student work	Career-center tool or service	Completion evidence
1	Orientation, privacy, and baseline	Select goals; review sharing controls; answer introductory and behavioral questions	Orientation resources; appointment directory	Baseline response, self-reflection, chosen goals

Week	Module and learning objective	Student work	Career-center tool or service	Completion evidence
2	Read the opportunity	Identify responsibilities, required qualifications, preferences, and unknowns	Job boards; opportunity advising	Annotated job description and requirement map
3	Inventory experiences	Identify examples from coursework, work, research, clubs, volunteering, and independent projects	Experience worksheets; career exploration support	Initial experience inventory
4	Understand STAR	Separate context, responsibility, personal actions, and outcomes	STAR worksheet and sample questions	Three structured story outlines
5	Explain individual action	Replace vague team descriptions with accurate personal contributions	Peer practice; coach drop-in	Two revised responses with clear ownership
6	Explain results and learning	Describe observable outcomes, limitations, and lessons without inventing metrics	Accomplishment-writing resources	Three evidence-grounded result statements
7	Connect résumé and evidence	Audit claims; link artifacts; create a role-specific résumé	Résumé review; portfolio support	Reviewed résumé and initial portfolio
8	Mock interview I	Complete a supported behavioral mock and select improvement priorities	Career-coach mock interview	Rubric, student reflection, revised plan
9	Build story range	Practice teamwork, conflict, leadership, failure, adaptability, and problem-solving	Reviewed question bank; workshops	Expanded story bank with coverage map
10	Research and motivation	Prepare “why this role,” “why this organization,” and student questions	Employer sessions; research resources	Source-backed role briefing
11	Discipline-specific interviewing	Practice technical, case, research, teaching, or portfolio questions	Program-specific career services	Track-specific exercise and reviewed feedback
12	Follow-ups and unfamiliar questions	Clarify ambiguity; explain reasoning; acknowledge uncertainty	Practice tools; coach guidance	Follow-up practice with reflection
13	Mock interview II	Complete a realistic simulation using the target opportunity	Approved digital practice tool or human mock	Full session review and focused retries
14	Format and logistics	Prepare for virtual, phone, panel, or recorded-response formats	Virtual-interview guidance; technology check	Logistics checklist and format rehearsal
15	Final rehearsal and follow-up	Complete human-reviewed practice; prepare a follow-up draft	Career Center appointment	Final mock, coach comments, readiness checklist
16	Capstone and next plan	Present the preparation packet; compare baseline and final responses	Final advising or reflection session	Portfolio, résumé, briefing, reflection, next plan

Michigan’s engineering career guidance supports using diverse examples—including positive and negative situations—giving specific personal actions, researching the role, and testing

interview technology beforehand. [3]

Weekly student rhythm

Each module should use a consistent pattern:

1. Learn: a short explanation and example.
2. Select: choose an experience or relevant artifact.
3. Practice: answer a question.
4. Inspect: review feedback and its supporting quotation.
5. Retry: change one or two specific elements.
6. Reflect: note what improved and what remains uncertain.
7. Act: save the story, update the résumé, or request coaching.

A deadline-sensitive mode should allow students with an upcoming interview to jump to relevant modules without falsely marking the entire curriculum complete.

3. Turning career-center tools into curriculum

Semester should connect tools to learning objectives rather than provide a directory of disconnected links.

Resource	Curriculum use	What Semester should retain
STAR worksheet	Weeks 4–6: outline and revise experiences	Student-approved story structure
Résumé review	Week 7: audit accuracy and relevance	Reviewed version and permitted comments
Mock-interview service	Weeks 8 and 15: human feedback	Student-authorized rubric and action plan
Digital interview tool	Weeks 9 and 13: repeated practice	Approved completion or feedback data, if supported
Employer information session	Week 10: research and questions	Student notes with sources
Discipline-specific workshop	Week 11: specialist preparation	Relevant rubric and practice assignment
Virtual-interview guide	Week 14: format and logistics	Checklist and student confirmations
Advising appointment	Week 16: next-step planning	Agreed plan with appropriate sharing

MIT offers behavioral mock interviews with advisors, while Michigan describes self-directed practice using Big Interview alongside career-staff preparation. These are examples of combining digital practice and human guidance, not evidence that Semester has access to those services. [4] [5]

For each institution, maintain a tool registry containing:

```
Service or tool
Institution and owner
```

```
Eligible users
Access method
Supported learning objectives
Accessibility alternatives
Data-sharing terms
Integration permissions
Source and last verification date
Fallback support contact
```

If a vendor does not provide an authorized integration, use an approved link and student-attested completion. Do not scrape private sessions or imply that a vendor score has been imported when it has not.

4. Interactive interview practice workflow

Screen 1: Choose the practice context

The student selects:

- An application, saved opportunity, or general practice.
- A question category.
- Guided practice or full simulation.
- Text or voice.
- Timer preferences.
- Whether to use selected résumé and portfolio material.

The interface previews exactly which information the AI will receive.

```
Practice: Teamwork interview
Context: Research assistant opportunity
Materials: Résumé v3 + two selected project summaries
Format: Text
Mode: Guided
Sharing: Private
```

Do not automatically include grades, accommodation information, unrelated coursework, private messages, or institutional records.

Screen 2: Prepare or answer

Guided mode offers:

- Choose a story.
- Outline STAR.
- Answer without an outline.
- View an example using fictional, clearly labeled content.

Simulation mode asks the question without showing an answer scaffold unless the student requests help.

Example:

> “Tell me about a time you worked with others to solve a difficult problem.”

Screen 3: Student response

The student types or speaks. For voice responses:

1. Generate a transcript.
2. Let the student correct transcription errors.
3. Evaluate the corrected transcript.
4. Identify whether feedback depends on incomplete transcription.

Speaking fluency, accent, facial expressions, and camera use should not determine the STAR content score.

Screen 4: Relevant follow-up

The simulator asks a question grounded in the answer:

> “You described what the team delivered. Which part did you personally complete?”

Follow-ups should probe actual gaps—not introduce unsupported facts or manufacture an adversarial personality.

Screen 5: Inspect feedback

Use a compact review card:

```
What worked
“You explained the project constraint clearly.”

What needs clarification
“The answer does not identify your individual task.”

Why this matters
“The listener cannot distinguish your work from the team’s work.”

Try next
“Add one sentence explaining what you owned, then describe two actions.”

Uncertainty
“No artifact was selected. Claim accuracy has not been independently verified.”
```

Screen 6: Focused retry

The student chooses:

- Revise the whole answer.
- Retry only the Action section.
- Answer the follow-up.
- Reject or challenge the feedback.
- Request a coach.

Keep the original response and the retry as separate versions.

Screen 7: Save and connect

After review, the student may:

- Save the response as a story.
- Link evidence.
- Suggest a résumé revision.
- Add a practice task.
- Share the session with a coach.
- Delete the session.

None of these actions should silently publish material to an employer.

Proposed session states

```
Draft → Context approved → Ready → In progress
→ Transcript review → Feedback available → Retry
→ Completed → Archived or deletion requested
```

Include paused, interrupted, failed, and review-requested states. A transcription failure must not erase the student's response or mark a session complete.

5. How AI should evaluate STAR responses

Separate three questions

The evaluation system must keep these distinct:

1. Structure: does the response contain useful STAR components?
2. Content: is it relevant, specific, and clear?
3. Claim status: what is self-reported, evidence-linked, contradicted, or unknown?

A well-structured answer is not automatically true. An artifact's absence is not proof that the experience is false.

Michigan's STAR guidance emphasizes clear context, the specific task, concrete steps, and "I" statements that explain the candidate's own contribution. [3]

Proposed STAR rubric

Use a 0–4 scale with dimension-specific descriptions.

Dimension	Weight	What a strong response demonstrates
Situation	10%	Sufficient context and a relevant challenge, without unnecessary detail
Task	10%	Clear responsibility, goal, or constraint
Action	30%	Specific personal steps, reasoning, and contribution
Result	20%	Observable outcome, limitations, and appropriate attribution
Relevance	15%	Directly answers the question and demonstrates the requested capability
Reflection	10%	Explains learning or what would change next time
Clarity	5%	Understandable sequence and appropriate detail

Action receives the largest proposed weight because students need to explain what they personally did. These weights are design choices requiring pilot validation—not a standardized or validated hiring assessment.

Scale anchors

Score	General meaning
0	No assessable content for the dimension
1	Mentioned, but vague or difficult to interpret
2	Partially clear; important details remain missing
3	Clear and specific enough to understand
4	Clear, specific, and appropriately nuanced

"No assessable content" must be distinguished from "system unable to evaluate."

Important scoring rules

- A result may be qualitative; invented numbers should never improve a score.
- A failure story can score well when the outcome and learning are honestly explained.
- Short responses can score well if complete.
- Explicit STAR headings are not required.
- Reflection is a curriculum extension, not an additional letter in STAR.
- Introductory, motivation, case, and technical questions need different rubrics.
- The system must not reward keyword stuffing or polished language over substantive evidence.

- Confidentiality limits should not be treated as dishonesty.

Automated feedback pipeline

```
Validate session and authorized context
→ confirm question type
→ obtain student-reviewed transcript
→ identify response passages
→ map passages to rubric dimensions
→ evaluate each dimension
→ attach supporting quotations
→ label uncertainty and claim status
→ recommend a focused retry
→ run feedback safety checks
→ display or route to human review
```

Treat job descriptions, artifacts, and transcript text as untrusted content. Instructions embedded in them must not change the evaluator's rubric, permissions, or tools.

Proposed feedback contract

This is an illustrative interface, not an existing endpoint:

```
{
  "rubric_version": "star-practice-v1",
  "assessment_status": "provisional",
  "dimensions": [
    {
      "dimension": "action",
      "score": 2,
      "supporting_quote": "We reorganized the project.",
      "observation": "The team's action is described, but your role is unclear.",
      "suggested_retry": "Explain the steps you personally completed.",
      "certainty": "moderate"
    }
  ],
  "claim_status": "student_reported",
  "verification_status": "not_independently_verified",
  "student_review_required": true,
  "human_review_required": false
}
```

Certainty labels should not be displayed as calibrated probabilities unless calibration has been demonstrated.

6. Automated grading versus coaching feedback

Semester should support automated formative assessment first. Official course grades require an institution-approved assessment policy and instructor authority.

Proposed course grading model

Component	Weight	Basis
Weekly practice and reflection	25%	Completion, engagement with feedback, thoughtful revision
Story bank	20%	Range, specificity, accurate contribution, evidence awareness
Résumé and portfolio	20%	Accuracy, relevance, organization, permissions
Mock interviews	20%	Rubric-based demonstration and response to feedback
Final preparation packet	15%	Integrated preparation, source use, reflection, next plan

Do not award points for receiving an offer, naming prestigious employers, disclosing private experiences, or using video.

Suitable automated checks

- Required deliverables exist.
- Selected sources have provenance.
- Portfolio links resolve for the intended authorized viewer.
- Required permissions are present.
- Story coverage includes assigned question categories.
- A retry or reflection was completed.
- Documents pass defined formatting checks.

AI-assisted, reviewable judgments

- STAR structure.
- Relevance to the question.
- Specificity of personal action.
- Quality of reflection.
- Consistency between a résumé claim and selected evidence.
- Quality of a proposed interview question.

Human-owned decisions

- Official grades.
- Academic-integrity findings.
- Contested evaluations.
- Accommodation decisions.
- Specialized technical judgments beyond validated system coverage.

Before activation, evaluate AI feedback against career-specialist ratings, measure disagreement by dimension, test accessibility and language variation, and establish an appeal path. NACE’s

assessment resources similarly emphasize actionable developmental feedback and examining reliability and validity; Semester's proposed rubric should not be represented as the NACE assessment tool. [6] [7]

7. Résumé and evidence portfolio integration

A. One claim, several representations

Use a connected chain:

```
Experience
→ student-approved claim
→ supporting artifact
→ résumé bullet
→ STAR story
→ practice response
→ portfolio presentation
```

Each representation serves a different purpose:

Representation	Purpose
Experience record	Preserve the factual account
Claim	State a specific contribution or capability
Artifact	Provide supporting evidence where available
Résumé bullet	Summarize the contribution concisely
STAR story	Explain context, action, and outcome
Practice response	Adapt the story to a question
Portfolio entry	Present evidence with attribution and access controls

Your existing career design already places artifacts and skill claims alongside applications. The implementation handoff requires employer access to approved evidence only. [8] [1]

B. Example integration

Student-approved account:

> "I built the data-cleaning script for our class project. It removed duplicate records and produced a report the team used."

Résumé draft:

> "Built a data-cleaning script to identify duplicate records and generate a report for a team analysis project."

STAR preparation:

- Situation: a class project required preparing a dataset.
- Task: the student owned duplicate detection and reporting.
- Action: explain the checks, implementation, and validation.
- Result: the team used the report; quantify improvement only if supported.
- Reflection: describe remaining limitations or future improvements.

Portfolio entry:

- Project overview.
- Script or permitted excerpt.
- Student's contribution.
- Team attribution.
- Validation approach.
- Confidentiality and sharing restrictions.

Semester should not transform that account into "improved efficiency by 40%" unless the student provides a legitimate basis.

C. Change and consistency handling

If a résumé bullet changes:

1. Preserve its prior version.
2. Identify linked stories and application documents.
3. Flag possible inconsistencies.
4. Ask the student to review affected representations.
5. Do not silently modify already submitted applications.

If a portfolio grant is revoked, block future access through that grant. Explain that revocation cannot necessarily retract copies a recipient previously downloaded.

D. Evidence status

Display separately:

- Student-reported.
- Artifact-linked.
- Reviewer-assessed.
- Issuer-verified.
- Restricted or unavailable.
- Needs correction.

AI may suggest a skill association; it cannot grant itself verification authority.

8. Implementation and activation plan

Work package	Owner	Dependency	Release evidence
Curriculum configuration	Career education lead	Learning objectives and staffing	Reviewed modules and accessible alternatives
Story–résumé–artifact linking	Career product and engineering	Existing career models	Versioning and permission tests
Practice state machine	Student experience engineering	Identity, storage, recovery	End-to-end interruption and retry tests
STAR evaluator	AI lead and career specialists	Approved rubric and evaluation set	Agreement, safety, and uncertainty results
Coach review	Career operations	Appointments and scoped sharing	Authorized review and revocation tests
Vendor tool connections	Integration owner	Institutional authorization	Documented scope and reconciliation
Formal grading	Instructor and institutional owner	Assessment policy	Human oversight and appeal process
Production activation	Institutional implementation lead	All required gates	Explicit authorization and support readiness

One existing policy conflict must be resolved before connecting academic records: the career execution handoff says AI never receives student records, while the broader role specification describes policy-governed contextual access. Begin with explicitly selected student-owned materials; do not infer permission to retrieve institutional records. [9] [8]

First pilot scope

Complete weeks 1–8 as a coherent vertical slice:

- Baseline practice.
- Opportunity interpretation.
- Experience inventory.
- STAR story development.
- Résumé and evidence integration.
- Human-reviewed mock interview.
- Focused AI feedback and retries.

Design all 16 weeks now, but activate automated evaluation only after the pilot demonstrates useful, understandable feedback, reliable permissions, accessible alternatives, and an effective correction path. This preserves the full curriculum ambition while making implementation status and institutional authority explicit.

⁂

1. The Main Semester design system (2) copy/ui_kits/student/Career.jsx

2. https://capd.mit.edu/resources/career-toolkit-interviewing/
3. https://career.engin.umich.edu/interviews/
4. https://capd.mit.edu/channels/interview/
5. https://careercenter.umich.edu/article/medical-school-interviews
6. https://www.naceweb.org/career-readiness/resources/
7. https://www.naceweb.org/tag/assessment
8. The Main Semester design system (2) copy/handoff/execute/07-community-career-family.md
9. The Main Semester design system (2) copy/handoff/specifications/role-system-execution-prompt.pdf
10. https://careercenter.umich.edu/article/campus-interviews
11. https://www.naceweb.org/career-readiness
12. https://naceweb.org/store/2025/drive-better-outcomes-measure-your-students-on-the-nace-career-readiness-competencies
13. https://capd.mit.edu/resources/the-star-method-for-behavioral-interviews/
14. https://careercenter.umich.edu/content/interviewing-resources
15. https://www.naceweb.org/career-readiness/competencies/the-nace-competency-assessment-tool/
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